CHAPTER 19

FRACTURED

March 2006

INDIA vs ENGLAND

Series drawn 1-1

We are both on a tour with the academy when we get the news. We're needed on the Test tour of India. They need reinforcements, and both of us fit the bill. I take one look at Alastair Cook and sigh. He does the same. We know what this means: it's a full day's travel to get to India. They are going to book us next to each other on the flight, aren't they? We've hardly ever spoken and now we are going to have to make small talk for a whole day. For some reason, at Lancashire we have already developed an impression of Alastair Cook. Maybe it's because he was a farmer. Maybe it's because he is handsome. Maybe it's because he is good. Either way, we have decided he's an arrogant, unlikeable, lucky kid who needs taking down a peg or two. We had peppered him with short balls a few months previous, eventually getting him caught out on the boundary. As he walked off, trying his best to avoid our advances as we ran in his general direction, shouting at him, it didn't seem exactly apparent what was so unlikeable about him – he took it very well – but our minds were already made up. I have blacked out this little on-field interaction when we take our seats on the airline, matching tracksuits, no collective history. I sit down, strapping in for the flight, facing forwards unflinchingly, bracing for impact, trying to invent in my head an excuse that I might not be able to speak for the journey. As he clicks in and the pilot begins the safety instructions, he turns to me and says, 'The last